

INTA 2120
Introduction to International Security
Spring 2026

Boggs B5

Monday & Wednesday
2:00 – 3:15 PM

Instructor: Sanghyun Han (shhan@gatech.edu)
Office: Habersham G14
Office Hours: MW 3:30 – 4:30 PM or by appointment

This is a Core IMPACTS course that is part of the Social Sciences area.

Core IMPACTS refers to the core curriculum, which provides students with essential knowledge in foundational academic areas. This course will help students master course content, and support students' broad academic and career goals.

This course should direct students toward a broad Orienting Question:

- How do I understand human experiences and connections?

Completion of this course should enable students to meet the following Learning Outcome:

- Students will effectively analyze the complexity of human behavior, and how historical, economic, political, social, or geographic relationships develop, persist, or change.

Course content, activities, and exercises in this course should help students develop the following Career-Ready Competencies:

- Intercultural Competence
- Perspective-Taking
- Persuasion

Course Description

Because security is a fundamental concern for individuals, societies, and states, this course provides a systematic introduction to how International Relations (IR) and Security Studies define, analyze, and debate “security.” War and conflict recur throughout human history for instance, but why do they occur, under what conditions do they escalate, and what patterns shape how actors anticipate, deter, or fight? Drawing on major theoretical traditions as well as historical and contemporary cases, the course introduces core concepts and terminology such as power, deterrence, the security dilemma, alliances, coercion, and escalation and shows how they are applied to real-world security problems. By the end of the course, students will be able to evaluate competing explanations of conflict and assess the policy trade-offs involved in managing threats in international politics.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Apply key concepts from IR and Security Studies to analyze security problems systematically.
- Compare major theoretical approaches and evaluate their explanatory strengths and limits.
- Use evidence from historical and contemporary cases to assess causes of conflict, escalation dynamics, and outcomes of security policies.
- Identify and articulate causal arguments, including plausible mechanisms and alternative explanations, in written and oral formats.
- Conduct analytical research using credible sources and communicate findings clearly through structured writing and public presentation.

Course Materials

Most readings for this course are available online through the Georgia Tech Library or are open access. You can find all course materials on CANVAS. Students are not required to purchase any materials for this course. Reading must be completed before each class. Students are responsible for all assigned readings, even if the material is not explicitly discussed in class.

Assessment Plan

Your final grade will be assigned as a letter grade according to the following scale:

A	90-100%
B	80-89%
C	70-79%
D	60-69%
F	0-59%

**Grades Are Earned:* Grades reflect the quality of work submitted; they are not based on a default 100-point system with deductions. For example, if you receive a 91, you earned 91 points, not “lost” 9.

Incompletes (I): Students may be assigned an "incomplete" when they were doing satisfactory work, but for nonacademic reasons beyond their control and deemed acceptable by the instructor, the student was unable to meet the full requirements of the course.

Withdrawals (W): Withdrawals from individual courses without penalty will not be permitted after 60 percent of the term has been completed, as specified by the official calendar, except in cases of hardship.

Attendance (10%)

This course expects students to attend an in-person environment and interactions on time unless there is an excuse or emergency noticed to or approved by the instructor. The substantive late attendance will also be marked and not be treated as full attendance.

Participation (15%)

This course contains components of lecture and discussion that require students to read all compulsory readings and materials. It also expects students to actively participate and engage during each lecture and exercise by being familiarized with the course materials. When discussed, we are less concerned with "right" or "wrong" answers than we are with thoughtful contributions that follow the discussion and either add to the debate or move it in a new direction.

In-Class Debate (30%)

One of the primary objectives of this course is to develop students' skills in applying course concepts to comprehend cases, drawing systemic understandings, and communicating the outcome persuasively. Each group of students is required to answer the primary debate question to defend their pre-selected particular aspects or components. This assignment aims to foster logical thinking and analytical writing skills as well as persuasive communication.

- **Position Paper (15%)**

The position paper presents the justification and logical reasoning for why the given factor or variable is more salient than the others.

- **Delivery (10%)**

Delivery evaluates in-person debate and communication skills.

- **Audience Evaluation (5%)**

Audience evaluation measures which debate group is the most persuasively delivered its arguments and therefore convinced the audience the most.

Quiz (20%)

The primary objective of a quiz is to assess a student's comprehension of fundamental and essential terms, concepts, and mechanisms encountered throughout the prescribed readings and lectures.

Historical Case Study (25%)

This presentation will explore one of the selected historical cases by applying various concepts and theories learned from the course. It will begin with an overview of the historical context of the chosen conflict or war. The focus will then shift to what kind of political dynamics exist and how it can be explained from systematic and coherent approaches.

Note: All written submissions will use Times New Roman 12, double space between sentences, 1" margins all around, and include the page number in the center of the footer. The required reference style is the Chicago Style.

Extra-credit

Upon consultation with and approval from the instructor, students may earn extra credit by participating in public talks. After attending, please write a reflective summary (maximum 500 words) and submit it via email within a week of the talk. Extra-credit may not exceed four submissions.

Grade Change Policy

Legitimate requests for grade changes are welcome and encouraged. You should, however, resist the temptation to file a frivolous request just hoping to "get lucky". Approach a grade change request as if arguing a legal case: you should have strong and convincing arguments and evidence to support your request. Be aware that appeals to the practices of other professors do not constitute a good argument or evidence. Note also that grade changes requests can result in re-grades either up or down (or left unchanged). That is, if the greater scrutiny demanded by a grade change request reveals your assignment to deserve a lower grade than previously awarded, and then the lower grade will be assigned.

Policies & Guidelines

Absence / Late

In-person student attendance is mandatory, unless there is a valid excuse or an emergency that is notified to the instructor with appropriate documentation. If necessary, substantial missing of the lecture due to late attendance will be also penalized.

Late Assignments

Late assignments will be penalized initially by one letter grade unless the late assignments are notified to and discussed with the instructor. Please submit your assignments with the provided instructions in a timely manner.

Academic Integrity

Georgia Tech aims to cultivate a community based on trust, academic integrity, and honor. Students are expected to act according to the highest ethical standards. For information on Georgia Tech's Academic Honor Code, please visit <http://www.catalog.gatech.edu/policies/honor-code/> or <http://www.catalog.gatech.edu/rules/18/>. Any student suspected of cheating or plagiarizing on a quiz, exam, or assignment will be reported to the Office of Student Integrity, who will investigate the incident and identify the appropriate penalty for violations.

Course Policy on Large Language Models (i.e., Chat GPT)

Although this course appreciates your creative thinking and novel writing based on your own learning and understanding, students *can use LLMs or other AI software* to assist, but not to write their work. *Please consult with the instructor* if you decide to use them for any assignments. This also includes the case of using "Grammarly" unless it is used for its original purpose, checking grammar. If you get approval from the instructor to use these AI assistant tools in your assignments, you must make appropriate indications that you used such tools. This may include appropriate citation(s) on the part(s) that AI software is used in the main body, and *an appendix that contains A) a specific name of the tool, B) the prompt that you used, and C) the original outcome that such tool generated*. No such indication is considered original and authentic production by students, and using AI tools without complying with this policy (i.e., no citation of such use but indication of using AI tools by an inspection) will be considered a violation of Georgia Tech's Code of Academic Integrity and severe plagiarism, which may result in a report to the Office of Student Integrity.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you are a student with learning needs that require special accommodation, contact the Office of Disability Services at 404-894-2563 or <http://disabilityservices.gatech.edu/>, as soon as possible, to make an appointment to discuss your special needs and to obtain an accommodations letter. Please also e-mail me as soon as possible in order to set up a time to discuss your learning needs.

Mental Health and Wellness Resources

If you or someone you know needs assistance, you are encouraged to contact the Center for Mental Health Care & Resources at 404.894.2575 (or 404.894.2575) or visit <https://mentalhealth.gatech.edu>. Georgia Tech has several resources for a student seeking mental health services (<https://mentalhealth.gatech.edu/about/scheduling-appointment>) or crisis support (<https://mentalhealth.gatech.edu/seeking-help/get-help-now>). Students experiencing an immediate life-threatening emergency on campus, call the Georgia Tech Campus Police at 404.894.2500. For more resources on

managing stress, anxiety, relationships, sleep, etc., please visit <https://mentalhealth.gatech.edu/mental-health-resources/self-help> for a list of free online resources compiled by the Center for Mental Health Care and Resources.

Student-Faculty Expectations Agreement

At Georgia Tech we believe that it is important to strive for an atmosphere of mutual respect, acknowledgement, and responsibility between faculty members and the student body. See <http://www.catalog.gatech.edu/rules/22/> for an articulation of some basic expectation that you can have of me and that I have of you. In the end, simple respect for knowledge, hard work, and cordial interactions will help build the environment we seek. Therefore, I encourage you to remain committed to the ideals of Georgia Tech while in this class.

Course Schedule

♦ = Mandatory | - = Optional

Part I. Introduction

January 12th: Course Introduction

January 14th: Necessity & Utility of Political Science (esp. International Relations)

- ♦ Stacie Goddard and Joshua Kertzer. 2025. "How to Put IR Theory Into Practice." *Foreign Affairs*, October 31.
- ♦ Stephen Walt. 2005. "The Relationship Between Theory and Policy in International Relations." *Annual Review of Political Science*, 8: 23-48.
- Philip Zelikow. 1994. "Foreign Policy Engineering: From Theory to Practice and Back Again." *International Security*, 18(4): 143-171.
- Paul Avey & Michael Desch. 2014. "What Do Policymakers Want From Us? Results of a Survey of Current and Former Senior National Security Decision Makers." *International Studies Quarterly*, 58(2): 227-246.

January 19th: MLK Day

January 21st: Defining "Security"

- ♦ David Baldwin. 1997. "The Concept of Security." *Review of International Studies*, 23(1): 5-26.
- ♦ Jef Huysmans. 1998. "Security! What Do You Mean? From Concept to Thick Signifier." *European Journal of International Relations*, 4(2): 539-561.

January 26th: (Cancelled) Guest Lecture by Ryo Kiridori (National Institute for Defense Studies)

- ♦ *Making Sense of Japan's Defense Policy: Continuities, Changes, and Challenges.*
- ♦ Buckhead Room, Exhibition Hall

Part II. For Security, By Security

Module 1: War

January 28th: Structural Explanation of War

- ♦ Kenneth Waltz. 1998. "The Origins of War in Neorealist Theory." *Journal of Interdisciplinary History*, 18(4): 615-624.
- ♦ Robert Jervis. 1978. "Cooperation Under the Security Dilemma." *World Politics*, 30(2): 167-186.
- Robert Axelrod. 1980. "Effective choice in the prisoner's dilemma." *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 24(1): 3-25.
- Stacie Goddard. 2009. "When Right Makes Might: How Prussia Overturned the European Balance of Power." *International Security*, 33(3): 110-142.

February 2nd: Rationalist Explanation of War

- ♦ James Fearon. 1995. "Rationalist Explanations for War." *International Organization*, 49(3): 379-414.

- ◆ Kai Quek. 2017. "Rationalist experiments on war." *Political Science Research and Methods*, 5(1): 123-142.

February 4th: Empirical Cases

- ◆ Philip Streich & Jack Levy. 2016. "Information, commitment, and the Russo-Japanese war of 1904–1905." *Foreign Policy Analysis*, 12(4): 489-511.
- ◆ Işıl İdrisoğlu & William Spaniel. 2024. "Information problems and Russia's invasion of Ukraine." *Conflict Management and Peace Science*, 41(5): 514-533.
- Robert Powell. 2007. "Allocating Defensive Resources with Private Information about Vulnerability." *American Political Science Review*, 101(4): 799-809.
- Nuno Monteiro & Alexandre Debs. 2020. "An economic theory of war." *The Journal of Politics*, 82(1): 255-268.
- Robert Powell. 2006. "War as a Commitment Problem." *International Organization*, 60(1): 169-203.

February 9th: Critiques

- ◆ Jonathan Kirshner. 2000. "Rationalist Explanations for War?" *Security Studies*, 10(1): 143–50.
- ◆ David Lake. 2010. "Two cheers for bargaining theory: Assessing rationalist explanations of the Iraq War." *International Security*, 35(3): 7-52.

February 11th: In-Class Debate

- ◆ Why Does War Occur?

Module 2: Components of War

February 16th: Grey-Zone Conflict (Chandler Thornhill)

- ◆ Tahir Mahmood Azad, Muhammad Waqas Haider, & Muhammad Sadiq. 2022. "Understanding Gray Zone Warfare from Multiple Perspectives." *World Affairs*, 186(1): 81-104.
- ◆ Frank Hoffman. 2009. "Hybrid Warfare and Challenges." *Issue*, 52(1): 34-48.

February 18th: Military Intervention (Dan Aum)

- ◆ Amber Aubone. 2013. "Explaining US Unilateral Military Intervention in Civil Conflicts: A Review of the Literature." *International Politics*, 50(2): 278–302.
- ◆ Vanessa Buschschlüter. 2026. "Why Has Donald Trump Attacked Venezuela and Taken Maduro?." *BBC*, January 3.
- ◆ Eric Levitz. 2026. "Venezuela Invasion: Why Trump Really Captured Maduro." *Vox*, January 20.

February 23rd: Grand Strategy (Dan Aum)

- ◆ James Winnefeld, Michael Morell, & Graham Allison. 2020. "Why American Strategy Fails." *Foreign Affairs*, October 28.
- ◆ David Baldwin. 2000. "Success and Failure in Foreign Policy." *Annual Review of Political Science*, 3(1): 167–82.

Module 3: Bargaining

February 25th: Coercion

- ◆ Tami Davis Biddle. 2020. "Coercion Theory: A Basic Introduction for Practitioners." *Texas National Security Review*, 3(2): 94-109.
- ◆ Richard Ned Lebow & Janice Gross Stein. 1989. "Deterrence: The Elusive Dependent Variable." *World Politics*, 42(3): 336-369.
- Paul Huth. 1999. "Deterrence and International Conflict: Empirical Findings and Theoretical Debate." *Annual Review of Political Science*, 2: 25-48.

March 2nd: Crisis Bargaining (+ Quiz)

- ◆ Keren Yarhi-Milo, Joshua Kertzer, and Jonathan Renshon. 2018. "Tying Hands, Sinking Costs, and Leader Attributes." *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 62(10): 2150-2179.
- ◆ Azusa Katagiri & Eric Min. 2019. "The Credibility of Public and Private Signals: A Document-Based Approach." *American Political Science Review*, 113(1): 156-172.

March 4th: Covert/Secret Communication

- ◆ Austin Carson & Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2017. "Covert Communication: The Intelligibility and Credibility of Signaling in Secret." *Security Studies*, 26(1): 124-156.
- ◆ Austin Carson. 2016. "Facing Off and Saving Face: Covert Intervention and Escalation Management in the Korean War." *International Organization*, 70(1): 103-131.
- Michael Joseph & Michael Poznansky. 2018. "Media technology, covert action, and the politics of exposure." *Journal of Peace Research*, 55(3): 320-335.

Module 4: Alliance

March 9th: Alliance Formation

- ◆ Thomas Christensen & Jack Snyder. 1990. "Chain Gangs and Passed Bucks: Predicting Alliance Patterns in Multipolarity." *International Organization*, 44(2): 137-168.
- ◆ Stephen Walt. 1997. "Why Alliances Endure or Collapse." *Survival*, 39(1): 156-179.
- ◆ Dominic Tierney. 2011. "Does Chain-Ganging Cause the Outbreak of War?." *International Studies Quarterly*, 55(2): 285-304.

March 11th: Political Dynamics of Alliance

- ◆ Keren Yarhi-Milo, Alexander Lanoszka, & Zack Cooper. 2016. "To Arm or to Ally? The Patron's Dilemma and the Strategic Logic of Arms Transfers and Alliances." *International Security*, 41(2): 90-139.
- ◆ Brian Blankenship. 2021. "The Price of Protection: Explaining Success and Failure of US Alliance Burden-Sharing Pressure." *Security Studies*, 30(5): 691-724.
- David Bearce, Kristen Flanagan, & Katharine Floros. 2006. "Alliances, Internal Information, and Military Conflict Among Member-States." *International*

Organization, 60(3): 595–625.

March 16th: In-Class Debate

- ◆ Is the utility of alliance high or low?
- Seung-Whan Choi. 2025. "Do Alliances Deter War?." *Foreign Policy Analysis*, 21: oraf027.
- Brett Ashley Leeds. 2003. "Do Alliances Deter Aggression? The Influence of Military Alliances on the Initiation of Militarized Disputes." *American Journal of Political Science*, 47(3): 427-439.

Module 5: Individual & Domestic Politics

March 18th: Political Elites & Leaders

- ◆ Jack Snyder & Erica Borghard. 2011. "The Cost of Empty Threats: A Penny, Not a Pound." *American Political Science Review*, 105(3): 437-456.
- ◆ Alexandra Guisinger & Elizabeth Saunders. 2017. "Mapping the Boundaries of Elite Cues: How Elites Shape MAass Opinion across International Issues." *International Studies Quarterly*, 61(2): 425–441.
- ◆ Stacie Goddard & Abraham Newman. 2025. "Further Back to the Future: Neo-Royalism, the Trump Administration, and the Emerging International System." *International Organization*, 79(S1): S12-S25.

March 23rd & March 25th: SPRING BREAK (Conference)

March 30th: Guest Lecture by (Ret.) Gen. Phillip Breedlove

April 1st: Mass & Public

- ◆ Michael Tomz, Jessica Weeks, & Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2020. "Public Opinion and Decisions About Military Force in Democracies." *International Organization*, 74(1): 119-143.
- ◆ Erik Lin-Greenberg. 2021. "Soldiers, Pollsters, and International Crises: Public Opinion and the Military's Advice on the Use of Force." *Foreign Policy Analysis*, 17(3): orab009.
- Anton Peez & Felix Bethke. 2025. "Does public opinion on foreign policy affect elite preferences? Evidence from the 2022 US sanctions against Russia." *International Studies Quarterly*, 69(1): sqae145.
- Jonathan Chu & Stefano Recchia. 2022. "Does Public Opinion Affect the Preferences of Foreign Policy Leaders? Experimental Evidence from the UK Parliament." *Journal of Politics*, 84(3).
- Michael Tomz & Jessica Weeks. 2013. "Public opinion and the democratic peace." *American Political Science Review*, 107(4): 849-865.
- Joshua Kertzer & Ryan Brutger. 2016. "Decomposing audience costs: Bringing the audience back into audience cost theory." *American Journal of Political Science*, 60(1): 234-249.

April 6th: In-Class Debate

- ◆ Which voice is more important in foreign affairs and national security?

Module 6: Emerging Issues

April 8th: Evolution VS. Revolution (+ Quiz)

- ◆ David Gioe, Michael Goodman & Tim Stevens. 2020. "Intelligence in the Cyber Era: Evolution or Revolution?." *Political Science Quarterly*, 135(2): 191-224.
- ◆ Jon Lindsay & Lucas Kello. 2014. "Correspondence: A Cyber Disagreement." *International Security*, 39(2): 181-192.
- ◆ Lennart Maschmeyer. 2025/26. "Deception and Detection: Why Artificial Intelligence Empowers Cyber Defense over Offense." *International Security*, 50(3): 86-126.
- Jon Lindsay. 2020. "Demystifying the Quantum Threat: Infrastructure, Institutions, and Intelligence Advantage." *Security Studies*, 29(2): 335-361.

April 13th: Internet

April 15th: Data

- ◆ Sanghyun Han. 2024. "Data and statecraft: Why and How States Localize Data." *Business & Politics*, 26(3): 263-288.
- ◆ Eddie Yang. 2025. "The limits of AI for authoritarian control." *American Journal of Political Science*, FirstView: 1-17.
- ◆ Aynne Kokas. 2023. "The Data Trafficking Dilemma." In *Trafficking Data: How China Is Winning the Battle for Digital Sovereignty*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1-21. (Chapter 1)
- Avi Goldfarb & Jon Lindsay. 2021. "Prediction and judgment: Why artificial intelligence increases the importance of humans in war." *International Security*, 46(3): 7-50.
- Fan Liang, Vishnupriya Das, Nadiya Kostyuk, and Muzammil Hussain. 2018. "Constructing a data-driven society: China's social credit system as a state surveillance infrastructure." *Policy & Internet*, 10(4): 415-453.
- Meicen Sun. 2024. "Damocles's Switchboard: Information Externalities and the Autocratic Logic of Internet Control." *International Organization*, 78(3): 427-459.

April 20th: Drone

- ◆ Antonio Calcara, Andrea Gilli, Mauro Gilli, Raffaele Marchetti and Ivan Zaccagnini. 2022. "Why Drones Have Not Revolutionized War." *International Security*, 46(4): 130-171.
- ◆ Julia Macdonald & Jacquelyn Schneider. 2019. "Battlefield Responses to New Technologies: Views from the Ground on Unmanned Aircraft." *Security Studies*, 28(2): 216-249.
- Andrea Gilli & Mauro Gilli. 2016. "The Diffusion of Drone Warfare? Industrial, Organizational, and Infrastructural Constraints." *Security Studies*, 25(1): 50-84.

Part III. Of Security

April 22nd: Economic Security (with Dr. Vagisha Srivastava)

- ◆ Council on Foreign Relations. 2025. *U.S. Economic Security: Winning the Race for Tomorrow's Technologies*. Task Force Report 83.

April 27th: Conclusion

- ◆ Jeffrey Ding. 2024. "The Rise and Fall of Technological Leadership: General-Purpose Technology Diffusion and Economic Power Transitions." *International Studies Quarterly*, 68(2): sqae013.
- ◆ Andrea Gilli & Mauro Gilli. 2018. "Why China has not caught up yet: Military-technological superiority and the limits of imitation, reverse engineering, and cyber espionage." *International Security*, 43(3): 141-189.
- ◆ Eugene Gholz, Daryl Press, & Harvey Sapolsky. 1997. "Come home, America: The strategy of restraint in the face of temptation." *International Security*, 21(4): 5-48.